

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called 'The Seven Great Corpses That Rise'

Ārya-Saptavetāḍaka-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 616 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ར་ལྷངས་བདུ་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའ་གི་ཟུངས།

Toh 616 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-Saptavetāḍaka-nāma-dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as the Noble Dhāraṇī Called "The Seven Great Corpses That Rise." As its name suggests, the text centers on a powerful dhāraṇī spoken by the Buddha in response to a dramatic incident in which rival ascetics sent seven animated corpses to attack him; unable to harm the Blessed One, the corpses instead overwhelmed his attendant Ānanda, prompting the Buddha to reveal the protective formula. The narrative is set on Vulture Peak Mountain near Rājagṛha and follows the familiar sūtra opening of Ānanda's testimony, placing this work within the broad tradition of dhāraṇī scriptures that emphasize the protective and apotropaic power of sacred speech. It belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur, reflecting the canonical status accorded to such texts as authoritative word of the Buddha.

In the language of India: Ārya-Saptavetāḍaka-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "The Seven Great Corpses That Rise."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling together with a great Saṅgha of twelve hundred and fifty monks on Vulture Peak Mountain near Rājagṛha, and together with him also was the venerable Ānanda, who followed close behind.

At that time, certain wandering tīrthikas sent seven great animated corpses in order to harm the Blessed One. When those corpses went toward the Blessed One, they found no opening and no target. Finding no opening and no target, they went to where the venerable Ānanda was, approached him, and touched his body. The moment they touched him, Ānanda was overcome with unbearable suffering, severe and burning, with feelings as though struck by death. Then the venerable Ānanda thought to himself: "I am afflicted with unbearable suffering, severe and burning, with feelings as though struck by death — has the Blessed One not noticed? That I have fallen into such distress — has the Tathāgata not noticed?"

At that time, the venerable Śāriputra and the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana were sitting not far from the venerable Ānanda. They heard of that great affliction that had come upon the venerable Ānanda. The two of them then went to where the venerable Ānanda was, and upon arriving, spoke these words: "Venerable Ānanda, having experienced this unbearable, severe, and burning suffering, are you saying that the Tathāgata has not noticed you? Have you truly said such words?" When these words were spoken, the venerable Ānanda replied to them saying: "Venerable ones, the sensation that has come upon my body is like, for example, having the top of one's head split open with a sword — what touched Ānanda was just like that. Ānanda, do not be afraid. We will place you on a litter and carry you to the Tathāgata. The Blessed One will protect you completely." Then the venerable Śāriputra and the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana placed the venerable Ānanda on a resting litter and went to where the Blessed One was, bringing him to the presence of the Blessed One.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, have you truly been struck by unbearable, severe, and burning feeling?" The venerable one replied: "Blessed One, it is so."

"Ānanda, therefore listen well and hold this in mind — I shall teach. The seven great animated corpses that touched you are mighty, hard to tame, and harmful to behold. What are the seven? They are these: the one called Garland-Holder, the Jewel-Holder, the Fierce One, the Outcast, the Peacock's Heart, the Life-Exhausted One, and the Horned One. These seven great animated corpses are mighty, hard to tame, hard to approach, possessed of great miraculous power, and of great force. Each of these animated corpses, if it so desires, can hurl even Mount Meru, the king of mountains, with the big toe of its left foot, and shatter the king of mountains, Mount Meru, into pieces the size of mustard seeds. If it gazes upward, it splits the earth open. If it gazes in any direction, beings die."

"If it gazes toward the intermediate directions, it sets fire by burning. These shall touch you. Nevertheless, by the power of the Tathāgata, by the reverence born of having heard the Dharma, and by the blessing of the Tathāgata, your body still lives."

Ānanda said: "Blessed One, please drive them away properly. Please turn them back. Please bind them with a seal. Please bind them with a cord."

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, therefore listen well and hold it in mind, for it shall be taught.

tadyathā: hara mahāgāre, ghasaravati, dhara dhāri, dharaṇi tsora tsoraṇi, karoti ti, koṭṭa samādhini, samara saraṇi, sarana koṭamiti, sambhave, bhavana, nāgare, bhadanī, sādānitī svāhā.

Ānanda, when these words of this dhāraṇī mantra have been recited fifty-two times and fifty-two knots have been cast, all amnesia and whatever harm has been done to the hearts of all spirits shall come to an end. One shall be freed from whatever has been wrought by all possessing spirits."

"Blessed One, excellent! Please do so. Moreover, please grant that he not die."

"Ānanda, therefore listen and hold it in mind well.

tadyathā: badza le bale, mahā badza le bale, bhili bhili, mahā bhiriṇī, nimirīṇi, hana hana hatiri, maca thā, mabizarathā, tire sthiramule, mathanirmavaṇi, cālani, mākanī, jambhani, pīdāni, bhayasvakṛṇi, bhagavati, tathāgata, bitathe, tivighadhare, parapradi, hare tiṣṭha, nīlavasani svāhā.

Ānanda, these animated corpses are agitated, wrathful, ferocious, and murderous. Recite this awareness-mantra twenty-one times over a cord of kemo-ruka fiber and cast twenty-one knots. Thereby the great spirit shall become utterly disturbed. All of them shall become wrathful, shall be shamed, shall become pacified, and all spirits shall be brought under control; all spirits shall be thoroughly pacified.

Ānanda, listen, for it shall be taught.

tadyathā: dara dara dara, kara kara kara, mahākakkar, cara cara, cadacara, mahācadacara, hala hala hala, hili hili, hulu hulu, hire bire, kiri biri, vairaviciṇi, karaṃkari, sarva bhūtānāṃ, prajambhani, nīlabara vasani, cacchu, cakra cakra, āyudhe svāhā.

Ānanda, these pacify all yakṣas, all rākṣasas (Skt. rākṣasa), all secret mantras, hungry ghosts, sorcery, and evil. They turn back what has been sent by a king and avert attacks by wild beasts. Recite this awareness-mantra thirty-seven times over a red cord, cast thirty-seven knots, and all shall be rendered paralyzed.

Ānanda, hold these mantra words in mind. Internalize them. Hold them thoroughly and well in mind. Apply them in practice. Therefore, Ānanda, you should retain them with mindfulness.

tadyathā: dhara dhara, dhādhara, khara khara, mahā khara, mahā bale, balanāśani, goṭṭānī, kuṭṭānī, saṃhāre, kuṭadaṃṣṭe, kakhakhare, makuṭṭa dhāreṇī, mulukke, kṣeṇika kainī ke, samēśmaśāni, kini, giriṇi, bhogi siri, sasāvetāṭ, kumāraka, kṛte svāsi, kinnibibuddhasi, vibudhya vibudhya, gṛhāmbhai, kṛtabhairava, vikṛtabhairava, mahā baye, kṛtvāna, harisi, kinna mārayasi, kinna nā sarva deva, nāga, yakṣa, gandharve, asura, sarva asura, sarva bhayaśamana, maṃsara svāhā.

Ānanda, should this awareness-mantra be used in a fire oblation, or..."

when bound with a cord, it destroys, brings down, and devours everything pertaining to the desires. Ānanda, retain this awareness-mantra that raises all risen corpses.

tadyathā: se me le, mahā ha ha le, hara dhare, ghora dhare, dharatti, ritti, virotti, kunatti, kuṭani, saṃgocani, kacari, khacari, marani, hu hu, mareṇa, mahā māla dhare, nayo namati svāhā.

Ānanda, these words of the secret mantra are equal to and like a fierce curse. In order to shatter all elementals (bhūtas), one recites it twenty-four times upon a clean woolen cord and ties twenty-four knots; all misleading spirits will then be unable to prevail. Ānanda, retain these words of the secret mantra. Hold them well. Ānanda, this secret mantra cannot be retained by just anyone. Ānanda, therefore hold it well.

tadyathā: cacchara, cacchara, mahā cacchara, ciri ciri, buru buru, mahā buru, sambhale, mahā sambhale, mahā bale svāhā.

Ānanda, in this world together with its gods, māras, and Brahmā, its ascetics (śramaṇas) and brahmins, and its people, I do not see anyone who would not delight in this secret mantra — it is a protection and a refuge. This mantra is irresistible: it burns, scorches, binds, destroys, and blazes. When the awareness-mantra is recited sixty-one times and sixty-one knots are tied, it thoroughly pacifies all evil and cuts off the awareness-mantra.

Then the venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, excellent! It has been well retained. Please cast down the knots. Please set the mudrā."

Therefore, Ānanda:

tadyathā: bha bha re, bhare, bharaṇi hara prahare, harani, kuthanī taṭi, leccha datti.

The awareness-mantra made by Brahmā is cut. The awareness-mantra made by the Great Lord (Śiva) is cut. The awareness-mantra made by Viṣṇu is cut. The awareness-mantra made by Śakra (Indra) is cut. The awareness-mantra made by the Four Great Kings is cut. The awareness-mantra made by the general of the yakṣas is cut. The awareness-mantra made by the moon and sun is cut. The awareness-mantra made by the planets and the sun is cut. The awareness-mantra made by the planets and the asterisms is cut. The awareness-mantra made from the directions is cut. The awareness-mantra made from the intermediate directions is cut. The awareness-mantra made from above and from below is cut. The awareness-mantra made by a god is cut. The awareness-mantra made by a nāga is cut. The awareness-mantra made by a yakṣa and by a garuḍa is cut. The awareness-mantra made by a kumbhāṇḍa, by a vetāla, by an ascetic or brahmin, by a kṣatriya or a vaiśya or a śūdra, by a man or a woman, by an outcaste, by a barbarian or a forest-dweller, by a lion or a serpent, by the mind of a wandering bird, by a yakṣa spirit, by a Tosala, by a Mudgara forest-dweller, and by the mantra-holder of any sentient being whatsoever — all such awareness-mantras are cut.

tadyathā: ga ga gārāli phu, mahā ga ga gārāli phu, viśe phu, śapara siddhi phu, caṇḍāle phu, mahā caṇḍāli phu, cogi phu, cimiri phu, cicimire phu, cakre phu, cakra dhare phu, kṛṣṇe phu, kṛṣṇe rūpe phu, caṇḍe phu, soge phu, pañcaṭali phu, pañcali phu, bhime phu, bhipāpale phu.

piṃge le phu, piṃgala, akṣe phu, anante phu, saminte phu, nāśanī phu, cchedani phu, bdicchedani phu svāhā. kṛṣaṇi, bhakṣaṇi, mārāṇi, piṇḍani, bindyanam, bhakṣaṇi, nāśāni, khādyakanam, gālabhinaśānī, dāhāmasi bhasma bhasma, masani, bandhanī svāhā.

Ānanda, these forty-two great commanders of yakṣa hosts are those who steal splendor in the night. Ānanda, at the moment the sun rises, there is one called the Great Zombie, the Harm-Doer. At the time of autumn, it enters into the trail of the sun's rays, and whomever those rays touch — touching them through the net of light — they become afflicted with disease. That too is cut by this.

Ānanda, there is also one called the Zombie of a Single Opening; that too is to be subsumed within this very dhāraṇī. What is called "Held by the King of Nāgas" — that too is to be subsumed within this very dhāraṇī. All nāgas, and all water-vessel spirits, and hungry ghosts, and all flesh-eaters — these too are

subsumed within this very dhāraṇī. The sky-soarer (garuḍa) too is subsumed within this very dhāraṇī. The treasure-holder too is subsumed within this very dhāraṇī. The wind deity too is subsumed within this very dhāraṇī. The son of the illusionist, Paropāṭi — Śerudro too is subsumed within this very dhāraṇī. The seizer of the aggregates and the seizer of the short spear — these likewise are subsumed. In the same way, the one accompanied by ministers, and the one accompanied by retinues — these too are subsumed within this very dhāraṇī.

In every direction for a hundred leagues,
by my cutting them all down,
what can the spirits do to me?
I have crushed all who harbored hatred.
The great powerful ones who kill,
what can the zombies do?
They too are entirely encircled
by my lasso on every side.
By that very lasso, all of them
are made dull and utterly bewildered.
By this, may I accomplish everything,
and may the words of the secret mantra be fulfilled.

Namas siddhānān. Siddhu natu mantra pāda svastire me sarva satvāñca
svāhā.

By whatever power all the buddhas hold,
and by whatever power the arhats hold,
and by the splendor of the sacred Dharma,
may all become fully well and blessed.
By the constant splendor of the noble Buddha,
in the face of all fears — svāhā.

The ritual is performed by reciting it sixty-one times, and knots are tied in a red cord of kaimepy thread, clean wool, and similar materials. Likewise, sprinkling with water is to be done. For all spirits, and those who cause forgetfulness, those who cause mental distraction and so forth, those who administer poison, those who cause poisoning, and for beings with two legs and beings with four legs — this is the supreme means of accomplishing universal protection.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the venerable Ānanda, together with the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas, rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

The dhāraṇī called The Noble Seven Zombies is complete.

Translated by the Indian master Viśuddhasiṃha and the monk Ye shes snying po's group. Translated by the Indian master Vidyākaraśiṃha and the zhus...

Translator's Notes

- The seven proper names of the animated corpses are rendered from the Tibetan as descriptive epithets rather than transliterated, since the Tibetan forms are themselves already translations or calques from Sanskrit and the underlying Sanskrit names are not recoverable with certainty from the Tibetan alone. The term "ro langs" literally means "corpse that has risen" and corresponds to what in the Tibetan zombie or vetāla tradition is a reanimated body animated by a malevolent spirit; "animated corpse" is used throughout as the most precise rendering. The Sanskrit title in the colophon reads Saptavetāḍaka, meaning "seven vetālas," a vetāla being a spirit that inhabits a corpse; this confirms the rendering.

- The mantra syllables throughout this passage are transliterated Indic material embedded in the Tibetan text. They have been transcribed as closely as possible into standard romanization following the Tibetan phonetic rendering, without emendation, as is conventional for dhāraṇī texts. No claim is made that these represent recoverable Sanskrit originals in every case; some syllables appear to be purely ritual phonemes.

The term rendered "cord of kemo-ruka fiber" translates a compound where "ke mo ru ka" appears to be a transliteration of an Indic plant or material name rather than a Tibetan word; the identity of this fiber is uncertain.

The passage ends mid-sentence, as the source text provided breaks off at that point.

- The phrase rendered "raises all risen corpses" refers to an awareness-mantra that causes reanimated corpses (Tibetan ro langs, Sanskrit vetāla or vetālika) to rise and stand upright — a category of harmful sorcery this mantra is said to counteract.

The term "kumbhāṇḍa" (Tibetan grul bum) denotes a class of spirits associated with the retinue of the southern Great King Virūḍhaka.

"Vetāla" (Tibetan tshor ba pa) is a class of spirit that inhabits and reanimates corpses; it also appears as a proper category in the list immediately above.

"Tosala" and "Mudgara forest-dweller" appear to be names of specific regional or sectarian mantra-wielding traditions; they are left as transliterations since no standard identification is certain.

The repeated phrase "the awareness-mantra made by X is cut" employs a ritual declaration of nullification, standard in apotropaic dhāraṇī literature, countering mantras of every conceivable source.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end with "□□□" — this is a colophon fragment indicating the beginning of a second translator's name or the name of the Tibetan editor who checked the translation, which is cut off in the source.

The names Paropāṭi and Śerudro appear to be transliterations of obscure spirit-entity names and are rendered phonetically as they appear in the Tibetan; their Sanskrit originals are uncertain.

The phrase rendered "water-vessel spirits" for གཤམ་མཚོན་པ་ is uncertain; it may refer to a class of beings associated with water vessels or pots, possibly a form of spirit.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.